of relative quiescence on the peninsula or at moments of extreme tension. Because Kim will not have the multiple forms of early warning that the United States has, he may well be more likely to interpret bits of intelligence and raw analysis in the most negative light. In fact, it makes sense for him to do so, since the risk of missing the signals of an impending US attack may be existential for him and his regime. It may be not only a panicked nuclear launch officer who misinterprets a B-2 show of force, say, as an imminent attack. Forward observers, North Korean spies, and possibly even hacks into foreign satellite systems all may give incomplete information that lead Kim's senior military officials to urge him to launch a preemptive attack of his own. Fear that the United States, along with its allies, may be able to target and destroy C2 nodes could be enough justification to start a preemptive North Korean attack, as any destruction of Kim's military capability might be seen by him and his inner circle as an existential threat.

This is as much a political question as a technical one, and what can be called "national warning" is where the human and technical elements come together closest to the decision-making process. Even after the Cold War, when the ideological passions of that struggle had abated, Russia and the United States came perilously close to nuclear war. In late January 1995, then Russian president Boris Yeltsin unlocked his nuclear football and gave orders to Russian ballistic missile submarines to prepare for a nuclear retaliatory strike. Just minutes earlier, he had been advised that Russian early warning radars had picked up what looked like an incoming submarine-launched US ballistic missile.

Unlike in 1983, the radars were not malfunctioning. A real rocket was shooting through a narrow air corridor that could lead to Moscow. And even though it was only a single missile, the Russians thought it might be designed for an electro-magnetic pulse (EMP) attack. Detonated high in the atmosphere, the gamma rays of a thermonuclear explosion can cause a massive overload on a country's electrical networks, shutting down military and civilian systems alike, including radars vital to air defense.[16] The Russians feared that an EMP would be